

The First-Paying-Customer Operating Kit

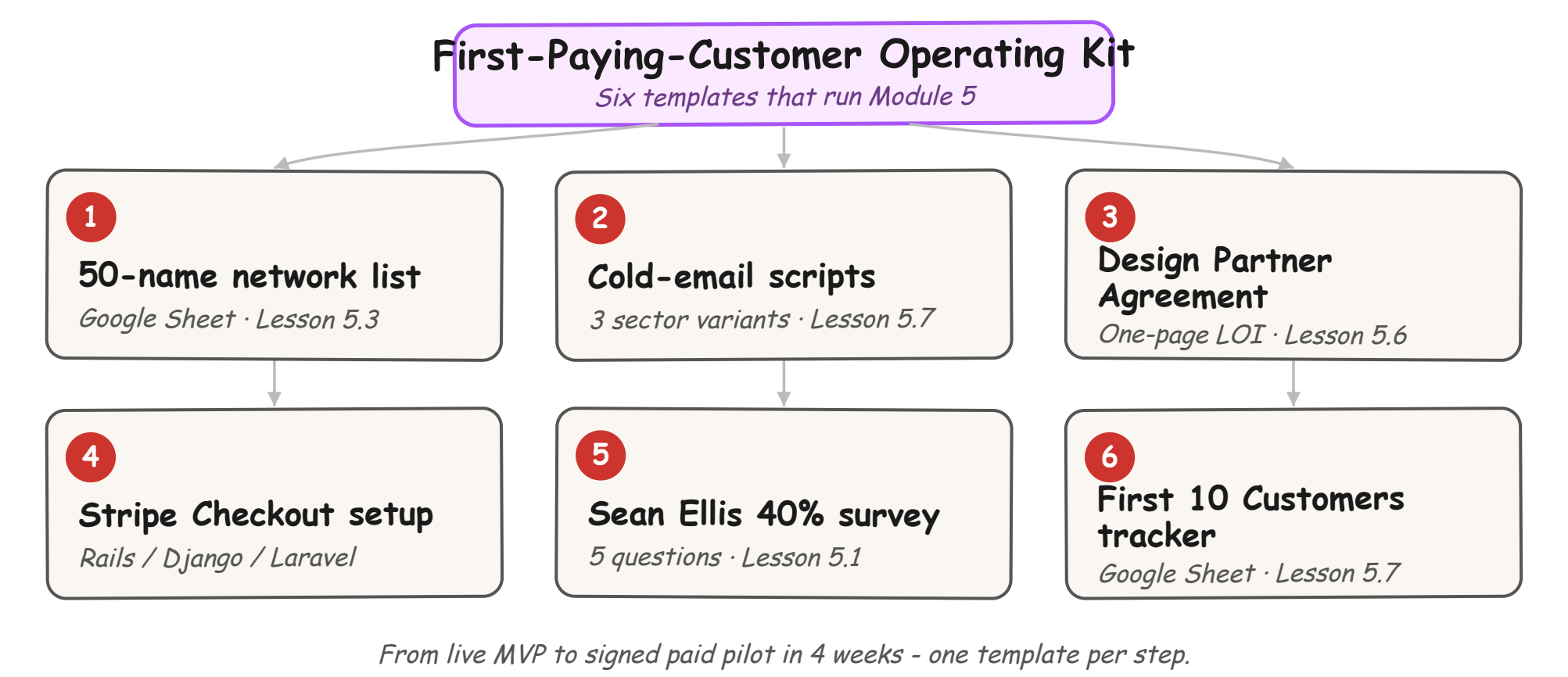
BY JETTHOUGHTS TEAM - MAY 13, 2026 - 8 MIN READ

Template companion to [Module 5 of the From Idea to First Paying Customer course](#). Six artifacts that take you from live MVP to signed paid pilot in 4 weeks - each one lives in a Module 5 lesson or its reference page, and this kit is the one-page index.

How this works: every component below links straight to the lesson or reference page that hosts it, copy-pasteable at the source. The DPA deposit clause is inline below as well. There is no email signup and nothing to wait for - just the links.

What this kit covers

Module 5 of this course runs seven lessons (5.1-5.7): the Sean Ellis 40% test, channel choice, the personal-network outreach arc, the paid-pilot contract, and the cold-outbound pipeline. The lessons carry these templates; this page is the index that points at each one.



The 6 components

COMPONENT 1

50-name network list template

The fill-in Google Sheet from [Lesson 5.3](#). Six columns plus four progress columns, pre-sorted by bucket: 5 champions on top, then 10 hot, 15 warm, 20 cold. Seed it with your 2.4 interviewees, 1.4 waitlist signups, and 2.3 30-name list before hunting LinkedIn.

✓ **Payoff:** turns a vague "I should reach out to people" instinct into 50 named messages going out by Friday EOD.

COMPONENT 2

Cold-email scripts (3 variants)

The verbatim 4-line scripts in three sector versions: B2B SaaS inline in [Lesson 5.7](#), B2B services and B2C in the [outbound reference](#). Each opens with one personalized reference and carries one currency anchor (deposit or beta price). Follow up with non-responders once only.

✓ **Payoff:** you spend 60-90 seconds per name on personalization, not 20 minutes deciding what to say.

COMPONENT 3

Design Partner Agreement template

The one-page DPA from [Lesson 5.6](#) - six sections plus signature block, plain English, no lawyer required for v1. Typical fills: \$1,500 deposit for a B2B SaaS pilot, \$5,000 for a B2B services pilot - both inside the 10-30% of year-one ACV band. The clause that carries the pilot, the deposit, is inline just below this grid.

✓ **Payoff:** makes the "we run paid pilots" conversation a 15-second handoff instead of a three-week back-and-forth.

COMPONENT 4

Stripe Checkout setup checklist

Five steps to a working Stripe payment link, no engineer required - the setup walk lives in [Lesson 5.6](#) with the framework detail in the [paid-pilot reference](#). Optional Rails / Django / Laravel snippets wire deposits into your app database after the first pilot ships.

✓ **Payoff:** 15-minute payment-link setup so the first deposit arrives Wednesday, not three weeks after kickoff.

COMPONENT 5

Sean Ellis 40% survey template

The exact 5 questions, verbatim, in [Lesson 5.1](#) - type them into Typeform, Tally, or a Google Form. The CSV scoring walk, including the per-segment must-have % formula, is in the [survey reference](#): pivot the Q1 column by the Q5 segment column and the per-segment number appears.

✓ **Payoff:** 24 hours from "I should run the test" to a scored result you can act on.

COMPONENT 6

The "First 10 Customers" tracker

The Google Sheet tracker from [Lesson 5.7](#) - columns for Name, Company, Bucket, Loom sent, Reply, Demo, DPA sent, Deposit, with color-coded bucket pills and filters like "Replied this week" and "Pilot landed this month."

First 10 Customers tracker - sample rows from the Google Sheet template

Name	Company	Bucket	Loom sent	Reply	Demo	DPA sent	Deposit
Priya Shah	Quanta Marketing	CHAMPION	May 6	Yes - May 7	May 9	May 10	\$2,400
Marcus Liu	Beacon Analytics	HOT	May 6	Yes - May 8	May 12 scheduled		-
Sarah Okafor	Mesa Systems	WARM	May 7	Yes - no fit	-	-	-
Devon Park	Cohort Health	HOT	May 6	Maybe - 5/9	F/u sent	-	-
Ana Reyes	Northwall Studio	CHAMPION	May 6	Yes - May 6	May 8	May 9	\$1,800

Color-coded bucket pills. Date-stamped progress. Deposit column sums to your live ARR.
Friday afternoon review: how many in each column, which rows stalled, what is your next move.

Names in this sample are illustrative composites.

✓ **Payoff:** turns Friday afternoon into a 10-minute "what shipped this week" review instead of a 90-minute scroll through Gmail.

The deposit clause from component 3, verbatim - copy it into Google Docs and apply the \$1,500 or \$5,000 sector fill:

DESIGN PARTNER AGREEMENT

3. PILOT FEE + DEPOSIT

One-time deposit: \$[500-6,000] (10-30% of year-one ACV).

Paid via Stripe before pilot kickoff. Credited dollar-for-dollar toward year-one invoice on conversion.

If Design Partner cancels before week 4: deposit forfeited.

Bonus: the pilot kickoff call agenda (60-minute template)

The Stripe deposit cleared on Friday. The pilot starts Monday. Your customer is asking “so what happens next?” - and the course’s [Charge Before You Ship](#) lesson taught you how to get to the deposit, not what to run after it. This is the 60-minute kickoff call that turns a deposit into an operating pilot:

Minute	Section	What to cover	Output
0-5	Introductions	Founder + 1-2 customer stakeholders by name; one-line each on what each person wants from the pilot (champion’s measurable win + power-user’s daily-job-to-be-done)	Each name + job-to-be-done in your Notion doc
5-15	Success criteria recap from the DPA	Read aloud the 1-3 success criteria you wrote into the Design Partner Agreement. Confirm the customer still agrees with them this week. Ask: “If we hit these by Friday week 4, do you renew at the standard price?”	One-line yes/no answer recorded
15-30	Friday demo cadence	Lock the recurring Friday 15-min demo slot for 4 weeks. You demo what shipped that week against the success criteria. Customer brings one piece of feedback or one new question. Calendar invites sent during the call.	4 calendar invites on both sides
30-40	Shared Slack / Discord / WhatsApp channel	Create the channel during the call. Add 2 customer-side stakeholders + you. Standing rule: bug reports go in the channel, not email. Channel name: <code>pilot-[CUSTOMER_NAME]</code> .	Channel live + invite link shared
40-50	Single point of contact + escalation	Identify the one person on each side who owns “is this pilot on track?” Customer side is usually the champion who signed the DPA, not their CTO. Your side is you. Escalation path: if the champion is unreachable for 7 days, you escalate to who? Document.	Escalation tree in Notion
50-60	Week 1 commitment + go/no-go gate naming	What ships this week (1-3 specific things, not a roadmap). When the go/no-go gate runs (end of week 4, by default - the DPA template covers this). What “go” means (renew at standard price) and what “no-go” means (refund or graceful exit, no hard feelings, written reference from the customer).	Week 1 commitment + go/no-go date on both calendars

The trap to avoid: skipping the kickoff and treating the deposit as the end-state. The deposit clears, both sides assume the other knows what happens Monday, and 14 days later the champion is asking “have you started yet?” while you are asking “have they used the tool yet?” - 14 days lost. The 60-minute kickoff is the cheapest insurance against that gap.

For your second pilot onwards, re-use this agenda as a Notion template - 90% of the call is identical across customers; only the success criteria + stakeholders change. The Friday demo cadence is the single biggest churn-prevention move you can make in the first 4 weeks: if your customer sees something new every Friday they are in for the long run, even if you ship small.

How to run the kit

The kit runs Monday-to-Friday for the four weeks of Module 5. The sequence:

Week 1 (must-have segment). Run the Sean Ellis survey (component 5). Compute per-segment must-have %. Pick your target segment.

Week 2 (personal network). Fill the 50-name template (component 1), seeding it with your 2.4 interviewees, 1.4 waitlist signups, and 2.3 30-name list first. Record Loom. Send champion + hot Monday, warm Tuesday, cold Thursday.

Week 3 (paid pilot). Send DPA (component 3) and Stripe link (component 4) to 1-2 warm leads who agreed to demos. Bank first deposit.

Week 4 (cold outbound). Filter 30 prospects in Apollo or Sales Navigator. Personalize 60-90 seconds each. Send the script (component 2). Track in the tracker (component 6).

By Friday of week 4, you should have: a segment-isolated persona doc, 50 sent messages with 30+% reply rate, 1-2 signed paid pilots, and 30 cold-outbound prospects with 3-5 booked demos for week 5.

One boundary before you start: the kit is not a substitute for a sales course or a CRM. It will not teach the conversational mechanics of objection-handling, so if you have never run a customer call, read [the Mom Test interview script](#) and run 10 user calls first. It will not track touch counts past the first 30 customers the way HubSpot, Pipedrive, or Salesforce does - past 30, the Sheet breaks and you graduate to a real CRM. It also does not replace the must-have-segment test from [Lesson 5.1](#) - if your overall must-have % from component 5 is under 25%, your pipeline will fill, the demos will go fine, and conversions will stall at the deposit conversation. Run the 40% test first; work the kit second.

Done: all four weeks are run and the week-4 outcomes above are in hand - segment picked, 50 messages sent, 1-2 pilots signed, cold batch tracked.

Next: the [Going further triggers](#) below - churn triage, pivot-or-persevere, and hiring, each with a read-this-when trigger.

Going further triggers

The continuation chapters kick in once you've passed the Module 5 gate. Read each one only when its trigger fires.

Diagnose what's slowing growth

Trigger	Continuation chapter
Customers leaving faster than you can replace them	Churn Triage Before Acquisition
A key metric flat for 2+ months	Pivot or Persevere
Hit the self-serve ceiling, time to hire your first engineer	Hire Track Reference

Working with a dev agency in the AI era

Trigger	Continuation chapter
Before the discovery call	“We Use AI” Follow-Up Questions
Surprise AI tokens on the invoice	AI Token Bill
Worried about AI supply-chain risk in the code they ship	Slopsquatting

Manage a hired team without writing code

Trigger	Continuation chapter
Need a structure for who reports to whom	Engineering Org Chart
Want a weekly heartbeat to confirm something shipped	Friday Demo Rule
Want a 3-question standup that catches problems early	Three Standup Questions
Need a plain-English weekly report from the team	Weekly Dev Report

Built by

[JetThoughts](#), a Rails-first dev shop that has built alongside non-technical founders for 20 years. We published this course because the same five mistakes kept showing up in first calls with founders. The kit ships open for the same reason.